

WHS Guidelines - Diwali



Introduction

Agenda:

- This session is to discuss a few key WHS areas of risk relevant to Diwali, but also for ongoing mandir activities.
- Each centre would be having is own existing systems, so this serves as a guide to align on baseline practices and is designed to be adaptable for each centre’s use cases.
- Our objective is to ensure that WHS compliance is maintained at all times so that BAPS can host events that are as safe but enjoyable as possible.



Planning and Co-ordination

- WHS plans should be finalised at least 2 months before the event, or at the earliest possible time.
- Event location and key details must be confirmed early (ideally 2 months before) for planning and co-ordination purposes. This is of key importance, particularly when engaging with external parties and endorsing our insurance policies.
- All WHS-related decisions must be communicated to the designated leads and volunteers should not make hasty decisions independently without consulting them first.
- Establish clear roles and responsibilities for all safety personnel before any event.



Equipment Setup & Safety

- Ensure volunteers in Diwali/KDC setup/wind-up – i.e., stage/stalls, etc. are wearing appropriate PPE.
- Ensure appropriate safety measures are followed when using ladders and any tools/equipments.
- All electrical equipment, cables, plugs, etc. must meet appropriate safety standards. Proper cable management should be conducted to prevent tripping hazards.
- Use proper outdoor-rated equipment for external events (weatherproof where necessary).
- If there is any specialised equipment that is used, it should **only** be operated by qualified volunteers.



Emergency Plan (incl. Vehicles)

- Emergencies can occur anytime, anywhere and require immediate attention and preparation.
- There should be at least 4 full-time First-Aid Officers rostered and present (with a Green First Aid Vest) at any given time to tend to such emergencies (2 male and 2 female, ideally). These volunteers **should not** be involved in other seva departments. A dedicated First-Aid marquee/area should be clearly marked on event maps/signage.
- If an issue has been identified by a First-Aid Officer, they should call and inform:
    - 000,
    - any medical professionals on-site (if required),
    - the Mandir Co-Ordinator
    - and the front security with the location details of the emergency. Security can also assist with crowd control.
- An emergency can also be identified by a bystander, who can call 000, hence, all specified people above should be prepared in case emergency vehicles do arrive unexpectedly.
- Upon arrival of the emergency vehicles, front security should direct them through the mandir premises to the location of the emergency.
- An empty room on mandir premises should be available to treat the patient in private. For outdoor events, ideally a marquee setup with essential requirements.
- Access to wheelchairs should also be available.





Emergency Evacuation Plan

- All mandirs should have an emergency assembly point which all WHS leads & volunteers should be aware of.
- For larger events such as Diwali, respective departmental leads should also be made aware of the assembly point and emergency evacuation plan.
- If the emergency evacuation point is where we are conducting out Diwali activities, then we need to come up with an alternate emergency assembly point.
- Please ensure that emergency evacuation doors, corridors (including fire-exits) are unlocked and clear of any obstacles. The plans should also be printed and shown around the mandir premises.
- In the event of an emergency, all designated leads and volunteers, especially sabha vyavastha and security volunteers should guide people to the emergency assembly point.
- Please work with your local WHS leads & volunteers to ensure this plan is thoroughly discussed and if possible rehearsed. This discussion can also be added to regular admin/coordinator meetings to onboard new volunteers if necessary and keep this topic in the forefront.
- When hosting events in external indoor venues, such as community halls, we should learn the specific emergency evacuation plans for that location.





Weather Contingency

- Back-up plans must be prepared for adverse weather conditions.
- Coordinate with relevant departments, such as decoration, sabha vyavastha, security to accommodate indoor events.
- Ensure emergency corridors and doors remain accessible regardless of weather plans.



Fire & Safety

- As we know, Diwali is a time of lights, firecrackers and with this comes a lot of added risk.
- Throughout the premises, there should be strategically placed and clearly visible, fire extinguishers and fire blankets (with printed instructions and pictorial diagrams on how to use them) to be used in a fire-related emergency.
- Provide practical training/demonstration on how to use fire extinguishers to volunteers.
- Fire alarms and other warning/alert systems should be regularly tested and maintained to ensure they are working before the event.
- **Note**: during New Year's arti, please ensure that extra care is taken, when and if, attendees are doing arti using individual divās in spoons.



Sparkles Management

- If kids want to light sparkles, they **must** be accompanied by an adult **at all times**.
- The adult will scan a QR Code as part of the registration form, showcasing their consent for their child to use the sparkles.
- After this has been signed, the sparkles will be given to the adults and volunteers will be present to light the sparkles for them with safe igniter methods (e.g., lighters).
- The area where sparkles can be lit **must** be contained and ideally barricaded/cordoned off, **away from grass** and other inflammable materials.
- First-Aid officers must be on standby in this area, ensuring their kits have treatments for burn-related injuries.
- Fire extinguishers and/or blankets must also be present nearby.
- After the sparkles are used, they must be disposed of using buckets that contain water/sand which should be placed at various spots inside the area. These must be clearly visible (with signage) and at elevated/accessible locations.



Rides/Games/Fireworks

- Ensure all external providers of rides, games and fireworks provide us with a copy of their public liability insurance – **if no copy is shared**, then we cannot hire them.
- Consult with fireworks providers on safety protocols, such as wind direction, distance from crowds, etc. and debris management responsibilities.
- It is the responsibility of parents to ensure that kids are kept safe.
- All outsourced providers such as rides, fireworks should be guided and shown a safe place for them to setup.
- Any items that is handled by BAPS, such as games (activities), Shayona food stalls, etc. is completely **our responsibility** so ensure that all setup is done safely and securely.
- We should consider allergen requirements of the attendees, particularly regarding reactions to face paint/henna. Volunteers at these stalls should ask for consent beforehand.





Food Stalls

- We should consider allergen requirements of the attendees. Volunteers at these stalls should ask for consent beforehand.
- Menus/signs for Shayona food stalls should contain basic allergen alerts, such as presence of nuts/gluten, etc. and include a clause to encourage attendees to inform volunteers of specific allergies.
- Volunteers in the kitchen/Shayona food stalls should be wearing gloves, hairnets, and other such hygiene equipment. Food that is leftover at the end should also be disposed and **not** carried over to the next day.



Crowd Management

- Plan appropriate crowd flow for the venue size and expected attendance.
- Ensure adequate space for movement, especially in high-traffic areas.
- Consider entry/exit points and their capacity.
- If possible, have security volunteers (both stationary and moving) around the venue.